Anupgarh to the 'real' desert further South full of undulating and shifting sand dunes, shimmering in the sun. One such task was at Tanot, a Battalion node we needed to defend. When we first went there, we were orientated by indicating some landmarks, all of which had unique names. One particularly large barren dune had been named 'whale-back'. I marvelled at the imagination of the person who could see whales in the arid desert.

On reaching Bikaner, after a period of settling down, the entire Battalion was to go out into the desert for our initial orientation training. In preparation, the CO, Lt Col Madan Das briefed us all and in conclusion asked, 'Any points anyone?' Dilbagh Singh got up and suggested that we should also carry our rain capes (coats). The assembled officers and JCOs burst into laughter—but the last laugh was Dilbagh's when a few days into the exercise, there was a massive thunderstorm in which we all got drenched to the skin. While the rest of us hunkered down in our tents, Dilbagh Sahib strutted about wearing his raincoat like an imperial cape. The lesson? Always trust your subordinates and listen to the voice of experience. I had my first taste of the desert (figuratively and literally) in this training. The fine sand would blow like mist and get in everywhere, including the food, which would always taste crunchy. I also learnt the importance of always using and more importantly, trusting your compass and never going out without it.

Maj JS Kanwar was one of the Company Commanders, a most respected and professionally competent officer, from whom I learnt a lot. In the evenings, when he used to come to the Mess tent for dinner, he would set the bearing for his tent for the return after dinner. We used to find it quite amusing, as the tents were hardly a few hundred metres apart. I would come from my Company locality, which was about a kilometre

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